



THE UNIVERSITY OF BRITISH COLUMBIA
Faculty of Forestry

Dear Dr. X,

Please consider our paper, entitled “Biological and climatic constraints drive reproductive synchrony” for publication as a X in *Nature Plants*.

How plants time reproduction given unpredictable environmental conditions is a fundamental question in plant biology. This timing shapes not only individual reproductive success, but also the reproductive dynamics of whole populations. Across temperate and tropical forests, many species align their cycles so that most individuals reproduce together, driving seed crops that vary dramatically from year to year—a synchronous phenomenon called masting.

What sustains this synchrony is effectively unknown. While climate is thought to synchronize reproduction, no climatic cue alone is sufficiently regular to explain the observed cycles. This suggests that mechanisms beyond climatic cues are required to explain the observed synchrony. Studies of fundamental reproductive biology and crop biology suggest that developmental constraints regulate reproductive investment within individual plants. Yet how these individual-level constraints scale up to shape reproduction across populations remains poorly understood. This gap limits our understanding of how reproduction is regulated within trees, and reduce our ability to forecast how forests will regenerate as the climate warms.

Building on decades of research on tree reproductive biology and long-term seed production data, we develop an approach that links individual-tree reproduction to population-scale dynamics. In particular, we integrate a well-established reproductive constraint, the temporal overlap between fruit maturation and floral bud initiation, with climatic drivers of masting. [...]

Our results advance fundamental plant biology by showing how the interplay between individual constraints and shared climatic cues provides a simple physiological mechanism for synchrony. We find that cold summers act as the critical hinge, driving most trees into a low reproductive state, and [setting the stage] for a synchronous mast year when a warm summer follows.

Our results also reveal that reproductive constraints buffer against the runaway effects of climate change. Contrary to the expectation that warming is already disrupting masting, we find that synchrony has remained stable over four decades of significant warming, suggesting that it may be more resilient than previously predicted.

Our work illustrates a principle that extends beyond forests and masting. Plant biological constraints can fundamentally limit the runaway amplification of climate effects on emergent phenomena at larger scales. Developing a mechanistic understanding of the biological and climatological drivers of plant timing will be critical to forecast regeneration and to understand the long-term responses of plant communities more broadly.

All authors contributed to this work and approve this version for submission. The manuscript is X words, with X references and X figures, and is not under consideration elsewhere. We hope you find it suitable for publication in *Nature Plants*, and look forward to hearing from you.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in blue ink that reads 'V. Van der Meersch'.

Victor Van der Meersch, PhD
Forest & Conservation Sciences
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References